

A Handy Guide to Niqqud



The dots and dashes that give Hebrew's consonants their vowel sounds — one at a time, plus the one distinction almost every beginner book leaves out.

The Core Niqqud

 Patach פָּתַח Sounds like "ah" (cat) A horizontal line sitting under the letter.	 Kamatz קָמָץ Usually "ah" (father) A T-shaped mark under the letter. Has a hidden second identity — see below.	 Tzere צִירֵי Sounds like "ay" (day) Two dots in a horizontal line under the letter.
 Segol סֶגוֹל Sounds like "eh" (bed) Three dots forming a small triangle under the letter.	 Hirik חִירִיק Sounds like "ee" (see) A single dot sitting under the letter.	 Holam חוֹלָם Sounds like "oh" (go) A single dot above and to the left of the letter.
 Kubutz קֻבוּץ Sounds like "oo" (boot) Three diagonal dots under the letter.	 Shuruk שׁוּרוּק Also "oo" (boot) A vav with a dot inside it, rather than a mark under a letter.	 Shva שָׁוָא Silent, or a light "uh" Two vertical dots under the letter.

The One Everyone Skips: Kamatz Gadol vs Kamatz Katan

Most beginner books simply say **"kamatz"** and move on. That shorthand quietly hides the fact there are two named forms, and only one of them is the everyday case. Knowing both properly, by name, makes the exceptions make sense instead of feeling random.

 Kamatz Gadol — "big kamatz" The default. Sounds like "ah" . This is the one most books simply call "kamatz".	 Kamatz Katan — "small kamatz" The exception. Sounds like "o" . Written with the identical symbol — there is no visual difference in ordinary print.
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So how do you tell them apart?

Not by looks. Kamatz katan appears specifically when the syllable is **closed** (it ends in a consonant, with no vowel following inside that syllable) and **unstressed**. Kamatz gadol is the default everywhere else — stressed syllables, open syllables, the rest of the language.

A few teaching texts and prayer books bold or otherwise mark kamatz katan to help readers spot it. That is a deliberate choice by that particular text, not a feature of Hebrew script in general. Out in ordinary print, the two are invisible twins.

Word	Meaning	Transliteration	Notes
כָּל	all / every	kol	One of the most common trip-ups for learners
חֹכְמָה	wisdom	chochmah	First kamatz is katan: closed, unstressed syllable
צְהֹרָיִם	noon	tzohorayim	Kamatz under the tzadi is katan

מחרת

the next day

mochorat

Same closed, unstressed pattern

The Reduced Vowels: Hataf Family

Four guttural letters — א ה ח ע (aleph, he, chet, ayin), and occasionally resh — historically resisted taking a plain silent shva. Instead they get a quick "hurried" half-vowel. These are the hataf vowels.



Hataf Patach
הטף פתח
A short **"ah"**

Shva plus patach, under guttural letters.



Hataf Segol
הטף סגול
A short **"eh"**

Shva plus segol, under guttural letters.



Hataf Kamatz
הטף קמץ
A short **"o"**

Shva plus kamatz, under guttural letters.

A quick companion reference — not a replacement for hearing these sounds spoken aloud.